

Headache - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1030 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Headache assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published when-to-get-help guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, are they pregnant or within 6 weeks postpartum, when did the headache start and reach maximum severity, and is it first, worst, new, or different? Include trauma, fever, neurological/visual symptoms, anticoagulants, carbon monoxide, and safeguarding concerns.
2. [YES_NO] Any recent head injury (within the last 3 months)?
3. [PAIN_SCALE] How severe is the pain, 0-10?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Disposition level 100

Has there been a seizure, numbness or weakness in the body or face, sudden extremely painful onset, difficulty speaking, balancing, walking, or remembering things, drowsiness or confusion, loss of vision, a non-fading rash, a very high temperature with a stiff neck or light sensitivity, or a recent major head injury with deterioration?

NHS.UK headache guidance lists these as emergency ambulance or Emergency Department criteria - possible stroke, meningitis, or other serious cause.

1. Disposition level 70

Did the headache occur after any head injury within the last 3 months, with none of the immediate life-threatening features above?

NHS.UK directs headache after head injury within 3 months to 999 or Emergency Department. This branch preserves emergency assessment while avoiding an unsupported rule that every stable case requires a Qatar ambulance; exact local destination and transport remain local approval required.

1. Disposition level 70

Are there vision or eye problems, is the headache triggered or worsened by coughing, sneezing, bending down, or exercise, is there vomiting, is a child's headache getting worse or waking them at night, or is there jaw pain when eating or a tender scalp?

NHS.UK guidance lists these as reasons to seek urgent clinical review or get an urgent primary-care review.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this a mild-to-moderate headache with none of the features above?

NHS.UK guidance recommends hydration, rest, and simple pain relief for uncomplicated headaches.

Advice

Qatar emergency headache response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for sudden maximal/severe headache, stroke signs, seizure, confusion, reduced consciousness, meningitis features, major head injury with deterioration, carbon-monoxide exposure, acute visual loss, or pregnancy/postpartum danger signs. Note the last-known-well time and do not give food, drink, aspirin, or unprescribed medicine when stroke, bleeding, or impaired swallowing is possible. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening confusion; new weakness, numbness, speech, balance, or vision change; seizure, neck stiffness, rash, or reduced consciousness.

Emergency assessment after recent head injury

- Arrange prompt in-person emergency assessment through the Qatar governance-approved pathway and do not self-drive. Call 999 immediately if severe or worsening headache, repeated vomiting, seizure, weakness/numbness, speech/balance/vision change, confusion, drowsiness, collapse, abnormal breathing, or other deterioration develops. Exact destination and transport for a stable patient remain local approval required.
- Call Back If: worsening headache or repeated vomiting; confusion, drowsiness, seizure, weakness, speech, balance, or vision change; collapse or abnormal breathing.

Urgent headache review

- Arrange same-day or next-day medical review through the approved Qatar pathway, especially for vision changes or persistent vomiting.
- Call Back If: vision worsens; vomiting continues.

Governed care for a familiar uncomplicated headache

- Rest in a quiet environment, maintain usual fluids if not restricted, eat normally, and avoid alcohol and known triggers. Medicine choice/dose requires age, weight, pregnancy/breastfeeding, allergy, kidney/liver disease, ulcer/bleeding risk, anticoagulants, and current medicines under the approved Qatar pathway.
- Call Back If: headache persists, changes, or worsens; new fever, neck stiffness, vomiting, vision, speech, weakness, seizure, or pregnancy/postpartum symptoms.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for sudden maximal/severe headache, stroke signs, seizure, confusion, reduced consciousness, meningitis features, major head injury with deterioration, carbon-monoxide exposure, acute visual loss, or pregnancy/postpartum danger signs. Note the last-known-well time and do not give food, drink, aspirin, or unprescribed medicine when stroke, bleeding, or impaired swallowing is possible. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Headaches", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/headaches/> (page last reviewed 17 April 2024)

Provenance

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